

Checklist:

Team Topology Checklist

1. Start with strategic context

- ☐ Team design is anchored to the company's mission, objectives, and scorecard
- ☐ Team design reflects product vision and principles
- ☐ Team topology supports product strategy, not just org chart convenience

2. Optimize for empowerment

- ☐ Team topology is intentionally designed, not inherited by default
- ☐ We are optimizing for **ownership, autonomy, and alignment**
- ☐ Teams are structured to do great work with minimal unnecessary coordination

3. Define the right number and scope of teams

- ☐ We know how many product teams we need
- ☐ Each team has a clear scope of responsibility
- ☐ Each team has the right mix of skills
- ☐ Team boundaries reduce ambiguity and overlap
- ☐ Dependencies between teams are understood and acceptable

4. Strengthen ownership

- ☐ Each team owns something meaningful
- ☐ Team ownership includes functionality, experience, quality, performance, and technical health, where appropriate
- ☐ Ownership is broad enough to motivate the team
- ☐ Ownership is not so broad that it overwhelms the team
- ☐ Ownership is clear enough that teams know what is theirs and what is not

5. Protect team autonomy

- ☐ Teams are given problems to solve, not just tasks to execute
- ☐ Teams have enough control to choose the best solution

- ☐ Teams can perform discovery as well as delivery
- ☐ The topology minimizes blocking dependencies
- ☐ Teams are not forced into constant coordination for small changes

6. Improve alignment

- ☐ Team boundaries align with business outcomes
- ☐ Team boundaries align with the product vision
- ☐ Team boundaries align with the architecture, where useful
- ☐ Teams are not trapped by legacy architecture or excessive technical debt
- ☐ Alignment reduces handoffs and speeds decision-making

7. Use the right team types

- ☐ We distinguish between **platform teams** and **experience teams**
- ☐ Platform teams provide leverage through shared services, tooling, or abstraction
- ☐ Experience teams' own user/customer-facing outcomes
- ☐ Platform teams reduce cognitive load for experience teams
- ☐ Experienced teams have as much end-to-end ownership as possible

8. Design effective platform teams

- ☐ Platform teams exist to enable other teams
- ☐ Platform work is separated from pure “keep the lights on” work where possible
- ☐ Platform teams have clear objectives
- ☐ Platform teams collaborate with experience teams through shared objectives when needed
- ☐ Internal platforms are managed like products when appropriate

9. Design effective experience teams

- ☐ Experience teams are organized around customer/user outcomes
- ☐ Teams are aligned by the most natural customer dimension, such as:
 - ☐ user type/persona
 - ☐ market segment
 - ☐ customer journey stage
 - ☐ sales channel
 - ☐ KPI/business outcome
 - ☐ geography
- ☐ Teams own meaningful end-to-end slices of the experience

- ☐ Teams are not fragmented into tiny feature areas

10. Avoid common structural traps

- ☐ Team topology is not dictated by reporting lines
- ☐ Team topology is not dictated by engineering skill silos alone
- ☐ We are not “shipping the org chart.”
- ☐ Design is embedded in teams, not treated only as an internal service
- ☐ Product, design, and engineering leaders shape topology together

11. Consider proximity and collaboration

- ☐ We have intentionally considered where teams are located
- ☐ We optimize for the product team first
- ☐ Product managers, designers, and engineers are co-located or closely connected when possible
- ☐ We account for proximity to customers, business partners, and other teams
- ☐ Remote/distributed arrangements have explicit communication support

12. Keep topology evolving

- ☐ We review topology as strategy, architecture, and scale change
- ☐ We revisit topology when dependencies become painful
- ☐ We revisit topology when teams cannot make decisions or ship simple things
- ☐ We revisit topology when ownership is too narrow or complexity is too high
- ☐ We try to keep intact teams together when changing responsibilities

13. Watch for warning signs

- ☐ Developers are frequently moved between teams
- ☐ Leaders often step in to resolve dependency conflicts
- ☐ Teams complain about too many dependencies
- ☐ Teams struggle to ship simple changes
- ☐ Teams have very limited ownership
- ☐ Teams face too much complexity across too many areas
- ☐ Major topology changes are happening too often

Quick scorecard

- ☐ Our teams have clear ownership
- ☐ Our teams can act autonomously
- ☐ Our teams are aligned with business and architecture
- ☐ Our platform helps experienced teams move faster
- ☐ Our experienced teams own meaningful customer outcomes
- ☐ Our topology minimizes unnecessary dependencies
- ☐ Our topology is reviewed and improved over time